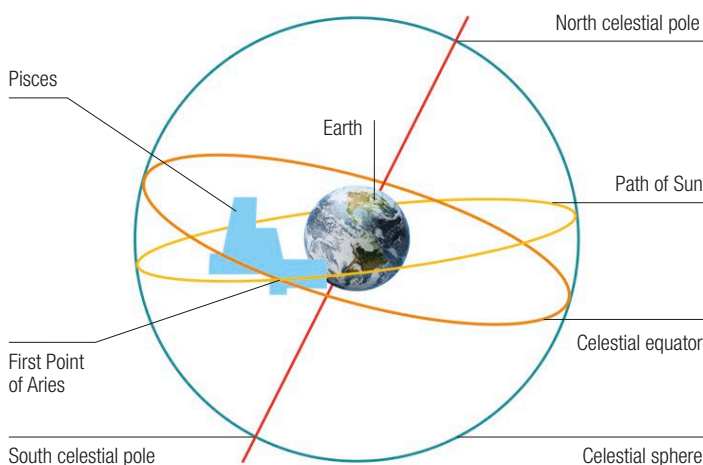


PISCES THE FISH

ONE OF THE 48 CONSTELLATIONS OF CLASSICAL TIMES, PISCES IS A ZODIAC CONSTELLATION THAT REPRESENTS TWO FISH. ITS MOST DISTINCTIVE FEATURE IS A RING OF STARS CALLED THE CIRCLET.

A faint constellation lodged between Aquarius and Aries, Pisces can be found by looking south of the Great Square of Pegasus and locating a ring of stars. Named the Circlet, this ring marks the body of a fish. Pisces' second fish faces the opposite direction but the two are tied together by "ribbons." The star Alrescha marks the knot joining the two ribbons. According to Greek myth, the fish are linked to the goddess Aphrodite and her son Eros. Pisces is probably best known for containing the point where the Sun crosses the celestial equator into the northern hemisphere. Called the First Point of Aries, or vernal (spring) equinox, this point is used to measure celestial coordinates (see pp.90–91).

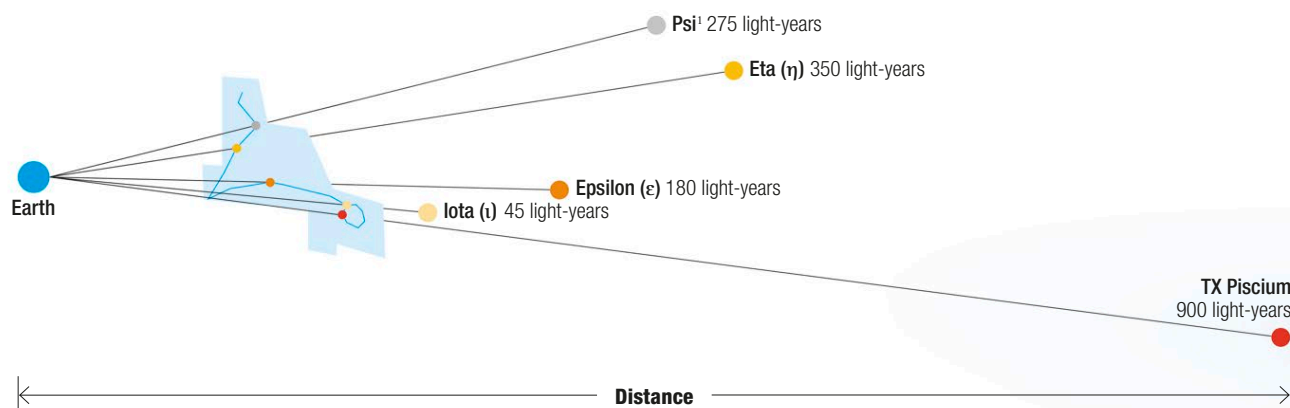


△ The First Point of Aries

Pisces contains the vernal (spring) equinox, also known as the First Point of Aries. This is the point at which the Sun crosses the celestial equator from south to north in March each year and is the point from which right ascension is measured. Originally in the constellation Aries, the vernal equinox has shifted position over time because of precession, the slow wobble of the Earth on its axis.

▷ Star distances

The nearest and farthest of Pisces' main pattern stars both form part of the Circlet: Iota (ι) Piscium at 45 light-years away, and TX Piscium, which is 20 times farther away, at about 900 light-years from Earth. These two stars are also the least and most luminous of Pisces' pattern stars, with Iota emitting about four times as much energy as the Sun gives off and TX Piscium about 690 times as much.



Iota Piscium
4 Suns

M74

A spiral galaxy 32 million light-years away and lying face-on to Earth. Its perfectly symmetrical arms extend from a central nucleus

Alrescha (α Piscium)

A binary star consisting of two white main-sequence stars of magnitudes 4.2 and 5.2

Cetus

Van Maanen's Star

